

June 8, 2026

Erin Cuenca, Principal

Vista MS (LAUSD)

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(818) 901-2727

Dear Principal Cuenca,

I am applying for the science teacher position at Vista MS for the 2026-2027 school year. Teaching has been a throughline of my life going as far back as high school, and I am eager to culminate its integration into my professional career.

As a black belt karate instructor in high school, teaching students spanning ages from 6 to 60 gave me a keen appreciation for the distinction between the roles of knowledge transfer and mental/emotional development in education. This sensitivity served me in college when I tutored friends and taught formally as a TA, and during my 20 years as a software engineer often presented to colleagues on new technologies and workflows. These strands of education coalesced while living in Korea, where I worked at an edtech Hagwon as a project manager publishing multimedia ESL textbooks and founded a Toastmasters club, developing a novel education program for ESL speakers to overcome their hesitancy to speak. Finally, over the past 5 years I brought these disparate strands together into a coherent whole when I founded a karate dojo where I have been developing from the ground up an off-the-mat curriculum relating karate to such diverse disciplines as etymology, geometry, pedagogy, and chess. For example, I relate the circular and linear trajectory of kicks to Euclid's treatment of lines and circles as fundamental objects of geometry, and show that a kick angled 30 degrees above horizontal rises half a leg-length above belt height - without mentioning the words sine or hypotenuse.

I am excited for the opportunity to further discuss how I can adapt my experience and skills to meet the demands of the classroom in order to best serve the needs of the students and the broader community.

Sincerely,

David Chung

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